

DREAMING AGES HISTORY · EPISODE 5

The Vikings

A Calm Journey Through the Viking Age

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A BEDTIME COMPANION

Two maps, a timeline from Lindisfarne to Stamford Bridge, the people and places you'll meet in the episode, and a short list of trusted books, museums and podcasts, for the evenings when you would like to wander a little further.

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Scandinavia and the British Isles

"Viking" first meant a voyage or a raider. Most people in the Scandinavian homelands farmed, fished and traded; some went out over the North Sea in clinker-built longships, and later settled where they had raided.



Places from the episode plotted at their real locations on a modern base map (Natural Earth). Coastlines are modern. The Danelaw label marks the general area of Scandinavian settlement in England; its borders were never fixed.

Places you'll visit in the episode

Lindisfarne: the island monastery raided in 793, long remembered as the start of the age.

York: Jorvik, a Scandinavian town whose excavated houses and workshops can still be visited.

Paris · Rouen: the Seine raids, the siege of 885–886, and Rollo's Normandy.

Oseberg: the great ship burial near Tønsberg, with carved wood and textiles.

Stiklestad: where King Olaf Haraldsson fell in 1030, soon honoured as a saint.

Dublin: one of the longphuirt, ship camps in Ireland that grew into towns.

Edington: where Alfred defeated Guthrum in 878.

Hedeby · Birka: busy trading towns of the Danes and the Swedes; Ansgar preached at Birka.

Jelling: royal mounds and Harald Bluetooth's runestone, claiming that he made the Danes Christian.

Stamford Bridge: Harald Hardrada's last battle in 1066, an end point for the age.

THREE CENTURIES, SLOWLY

A timeline, 793 to 1066



793
Raiders strike the monastery of Lindisfarne.

834
The Oseberg ship is buried in southern Norway.

840s
Ship camps (longphuirt) are founded in Ireland; Dublin grows from one.

c. 865
A "Great Army" lands in England.

878
Alfred defeats Guthrum at Edington; the Danelaw takes shape.

Late 800s
Settlers begin to arrive in Iceland.

885–886
Paris is besieged.

c. 911
Rollo receives lands on the lower Seine: the beginning of Normandy.

c. 930
The Althing, Iceland's assembly, first meets.

937
Brunanburh: an English victory at a site still debated.

c. 965
Harald Bluetooth raises the great runestone at Jelling.

c. 985/986
Erik the Red leads settlers to Greenland.

c. 988
Vladimir of Kyiv accepts Christianity.

c. 1000
Norse people camp at L'Anse aux Meadows; Iceland accepts Christianity at the Althing.

1014
The Battle of Clontarf near Dublin.

1016
Cnut becomes king of England, and later of Denmark and Norway.

1030
Olaf Haraldsson falls at Stiklestad.

1066
Harald Hardrada dies at Stamford Bridge.

Early dates are approximate; some, such as Iceland's conversion around 1000, rest on later saga tradition.

From Vinland to the Volga



Approximate extent of the Scandinavian homelands and of Kyivan Rus around 900, simplified from the open historical-basemaps dataset; borders are approximate. Norse settlers reached Iceland, Greenland and briefly Newfoundland, while Rus traders followed the rivers south, bringing Islamic silver dirhams north and later serving in Byzantium's Varangian Guard.

People you'll meet

Alfred the Great: king of Wessex who defeated Guthrum at Edington in 878.

Æthelflæd: Lady of the Mercians, who with her brother Edward won back Danelaw lands.

Erik the Red: led settlers from Iceland to Greenland around 985/986.

Harald Bluetooth: Danish king of the Jelling stone.

Olaf Haraldsson: king of Norway, killed at Stiklestad in 1030 and honoured as St Olaf.

Ansgar: missionary who preached at Birka in the 800s.

Guthrum: Danish leader who made peace with Alfred and was baptised.

Rollo: Norse leader granted lands on the Seine around 911: the first ruler of Normandy.

Leif Erikson: his son, who sailed west to Vinland in the sagas.

Cnut: king of England from 1016, ruler of a North Sea empire.

Harald Hardrada: Varangian veteran and king of Norway; fell at Stamford Bridge.

Snorri Sturluson: Icelandic writer of the 1200s who wrote down much Norse myth, through Christian eyes.

Legend or history?

Much of what we "know" about Vikings comes from sagas written down centuries later, in Christian Iceland. Horned helmets are a modern invention, the size of the Great Army is debated, and Clontarf in 1014 was not a simple end of the Vikings in Ireland. The episode keeps these apart from what archaeology and earlier sources show.

FOR ANOTHER QUIET EVENING

Learn more





Artistic impressions of a Norse settlement and of longships in a fjord, made for the episode. They are not historical records.

Books

Children of Ash and Elm: A History of the Vikings ↗, Neil Price (Basic Books, 2020).

The Age of the Vikings ↗, Anders Winroth (Princeton University Press, 2016).

The Vikings: A History ↗, Robert Ferguson (Penguin, 2010).

Beyond the Northlands: Viking Voyages and the Old Norse Sagas ↗, Eleanor Rosamund Barraclough (Oxford University Press, 2016).

The Sagas of Icelanders ↗, preface by Jane Smiley, intro. Robert Kellogg (Penguin, 2001).

Norse Mythology ↗, Neil Gaiman (W. W. Norton), a retelling of the myths.

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Full reading list ↗

Museums & places

Viking Ship Museum, Roskilde: five ships raised from the fjord.

Museum of Cultural History, Oslo: home of the Oseberg ship.

Jorvik Viking Centre, York.

L'Anse aux Meadows, Newfoundland: Parks Canada's Norse site.

Podcasts

In Our Time: The Volga Vikings, BBC Radio 4, with Neil Price.

In Our Time: The Norse Gods, BBC Radio 4.

"A sail lowered in a calm inlet. A spindle still turning in a woman's hand. A rune stone wet with rain beside a road."

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Dreaming Ages History · Narration is AI-generated text-to-speech; illustrations are AI-generated artistic impressions. Facts follow the episode script and its sources. Maps drawn from real coordinates: Natural Earth; historical borders simplified from the open historical-basemaps dataset (A. Ourednik). Free for personal use. Sleep well. 🌙